disappointment that it has not gone far enough. These concerns echo those of American and Indian policymakers in the years this book covers. Indian policymakers are anxious about the impact of closer relations with the US on its relations with Russia and China, and its strategic autonomy. They simultaneously also question American reliability and its approach in the region. American officials, on their part, worry about Indian ability and willingness to play the role they have envisioned for it vis-à-vis China. And they hold India's nonalignment, which they see as an ideological aversion to alliances, as responsible for India's reluctance to work with the US in tackling the China challenge.

The past shapes many of today's perceptions and concerns. It influences the ideas of American and Indian foreign policymakers and the publics about what India has done and can do, and about the limits and possibilities of the US-India relationship. Thus it is important to continue to probe that past, which is what this book has sought to do in the case of the US-India-China triangle. We now know aspects that allow us to revisit some assumptions based on the past and learn some lessons for the present and future.

Rethinking Nonalignment

Nonalignment is a much-used term that means a number of different things and encompasses various elements of Indian foreign policy. It has also been interpreted in numerous ways. It has been seen as either a defensive response or a rejection of the Cold War bipolar framework, or an offensive reaction to gain leverage in the Cold War.[4] Others see nonalignment as having been a strategy of isolation, noting "Nonalignment as a foreign policy was designed to keep India out of the way of the storms and stresses of the Cold War, allowing India to concentrate on its economic development."[5]

This strategy that has come to be called nonalignment had elements of both defense and offense. Early in independent India's history, the ruling Indian National Congress "agreed that India was to enjoy complete and uncompromising autonomy in its strategic decision-making process."[6] But as this book shows, Indian policymakers soon acknowledged the reality that even if India wanted to, it could not isolate itself, and, moreover, it was